

A Healthy India

Health is not valued till sickness comes. And Covid-19 has shown us that for India to be truly a world-class economy, its healthcare system has to be robust

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S **THANA BALA**—is a Sanskrit phrase, which translates poorly to “positional strength” and relates to the influence a place has on a person. There has never been a time when the *Sthana Bala* of being an Indian in India has been stronger. A country has to get many things right to make its citizens feel this. Powered by GDP growth of 7.3%, India has one of the youngest populations. The demographic dividend that India has been enjoying since 2018 will last us 40 years. No other country of relevance can talk of this window of opportunity. However, historian Thomas Fuller talked about this in the 1600s and Covid-19 has shown us that “health is not valued till sickness comes”. Healthcare in India today is characterised by significant developments but yet there are substantial challenges that need rapid addressal. As the world looks at India, we need to redefine our healthcare to truly enjoy economic growth.

India's healthcare sector has grown at a compound annual rate of 22% for nearly 10 years. This growth is driven by factors such as investment in healthcare infrastructure, growth in insurance and diagnostics. But we need to now solve for an ageing population, rapid urbanisation, financial constraints, and historically low levels of public spending.

The US spends 17% of its



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GDP on healthcare, while India spends about 4%. In addition to the inadequate spend, the demographic shift in India is significant. The UN Population Fund estimates the size of the elderly population in India to nearly double to 192 million by 2030. Rapid urbanisation has seen multi-morbidity becoming a significant health concern. This phenomenon makes low-income groups more vulnerable to multiple health issues. This morbidity is linked to adverse outcomes such as disability, heightened utilisation of medical resources, and increased health expenditure. Financial constraints and historically low public healthcare funding have led to substantial out-of-pocket expenditure, pushing households, especially those in the lowest income groups, further below the poverty line.

There are five key healthcare transformations needed.

Address healthcare holistically

We need to ensure that every aspect of healthcare—diagnosis, treatment and adherence—is addressed. Our hospitals, doctors, and even pharmaceutical companies are overburdened. We need more doctors, more hospital beds, and more healthcare providers.

India targets eradicating one of its most persistent healthcare issues, tuberculosis, by 2025, leveraging initiatives such as drug sensitivity testing, improved diagnostics, strengthened healthcare infrastruc-